

Decorated and Perpendicular

Decorated architecture, also called Geometric, Middle Pointed or Curvilinear, has a lighter feel than Early English. It is characterized by ornately patterned windows divided by closely set mullions (vertical stone divisions), usually including trefoils and quatrefoils. The proliferation of flying buttresses saw interiors soar even higher, with slimmer columns, larger windows and greater decoration. Vaulting became lighter, with lierne (short-branch) or tierceron (full-length) 'spare ribs' making elaborate patterns, such as those at Lincoln, Exeter, Wells (opposite) and Bristol cathedrals; fan vaulting made its debut at Gloucester in the 1350s.

The chief characteristic of Perpendicular (or Rectilinear), England's final phase of Gothic, was an emphasis on vertical lines, most obviously in ranks of particularly close-set window mullions. Fan vaulting reached its zenith, too, with particularly fine examples at King's College Chapel, Cambridge (1446–1515) and Henry VII's Chapel at Westminster Abbey (1503–19).

